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The Masai

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 132

Culture (OWC): [Maasai \(FL12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1895-1907

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Kenya And Tanzania

Section Title(S): XI.

The fact that the Masai so frequently attack with great success and often strike down to the last man even trade caravans armed with muzzle-loaders they owe nowadays less to their strength than to their cunning. A caravan traveling through the steppes will today be joined by a pair of seemingly poor, hungry Masai, who greet the porters in a friendly way and willingly give them information about the next camping place, etc. Incidentally, but with all the fabricated details possible, it is related that the Masai had recently been in the vicinity, but had now moved off and were camping far from here. After the two have eaten with the porters in the evening, one of them disappears during the night and reports to the warriors of his kraal what has been discovered. Before dawn he is back in the camp and the two travel on with the caravan, having by now become friendly with its men. There are found again the next day two or three "poor" Masai, who pass themselves off as Wandorobbo -- as the first also often do. They have brought along their alleged entire possessions, consisting of a few rhinoceros horns, to sell or even as gifts. They too remain with the caravan; they eat, chat, and joke with the porters and on this occasion reveal a keen understanding in recognizing how far the latter trust them, whether they feel quite safe, etc. If they believe the caravan is quite unconcerned, one of the Masai guests, on this or the next night, fetches the warriors, who then, as a rule, between midnight and three o'clock in the morning, when the porters are sleeping most soundly, attack the camp and without difficulty massacre the sleepers.

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